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PATNA
SHAILESH KUMAR, 52
Financial advisor

Stretching Their Budget

Of their monthly income of Rs 75,000, Kumar and his homemaker wife Manorama set Rs 65,000 aside for their household needs. Much of this goes towards the Rs 18,000 EMI they pay on their Rs 20 lakh home loan, the Rs 12,000 school fees for their two children and the remainder on groceries, phone and power bills and fuel. It leaves the couple with very little to save.

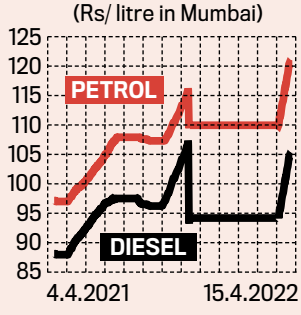
Of late, their expenses have risen by 30 per cent. "We need Rs 1,000 every day just to meet our daily household expenses," says Kumar. The couple have cut down on all unnecessary travel, even if it means not attending a wedding or social function, or not buying clothes during festivals. Even watching a movie in a theatre has become a luxury. Kumar can afford to buy a car, but given the rising fuel costs, he has decided to retain his Bajaj Platina motorbike. Kumar wants petrol to be brought under GST so that its cost can come down. He also laments that the past few budgets have not accorded any tax relief to people like him. They want our votes but don't address our woes, he says.

– Amitabh Srivastava

FUEL PRICES

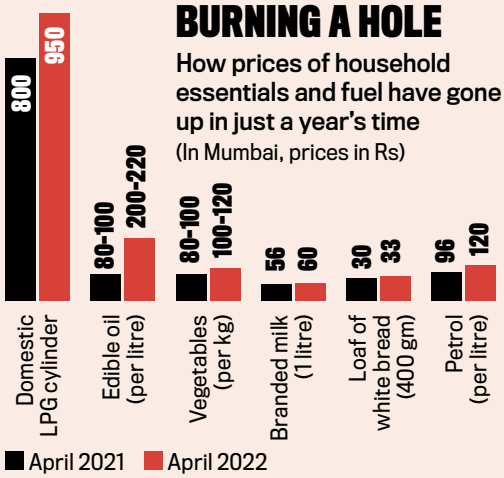
THE HEAT IS ON

Post assembly polls, petrol prices have risen as much as Rs 10 a litre



BURNING A HOLE

How prices of household essentials and fuel have gone up in just a year's time
(In Mumbai, prices in Rs)



"Manufacturers enter into short-term contracts with buyers which have no clause for price escalation. The only alternative is to reduce their own margins"

– ANIL BHARDWAJ
Secretary-general, FISME

has altered drastically (since October, when the RBI last came out with its policy announcements), with the escalating geopolitical situation clouding the outlook for both growth and inflation in India and across the world, warranting a revision in forecasts," the central bank said. "Amid persisting global supply chain disruptions, elevated energy and input prices and tighter labour markets, apprehensions of heightened global financial and commodity market volatility come together in a perfect storm."

With inflation breaching targets, major advanced economies are unwinding their accommodative monetary policies. Stock markets have remained highly volatile, and currency prices have dipped compared to the dollar. Ditto for the rupee, which is trading at nearly Rs